AGNI-I, 1989

BALLISTIC MUSCLE

In 1989, the launch of its first intermediate-range ballistic missile, Agni, elevated India into an elite club. Agni-I laid the foundation of the country's emergence as a regional superpower

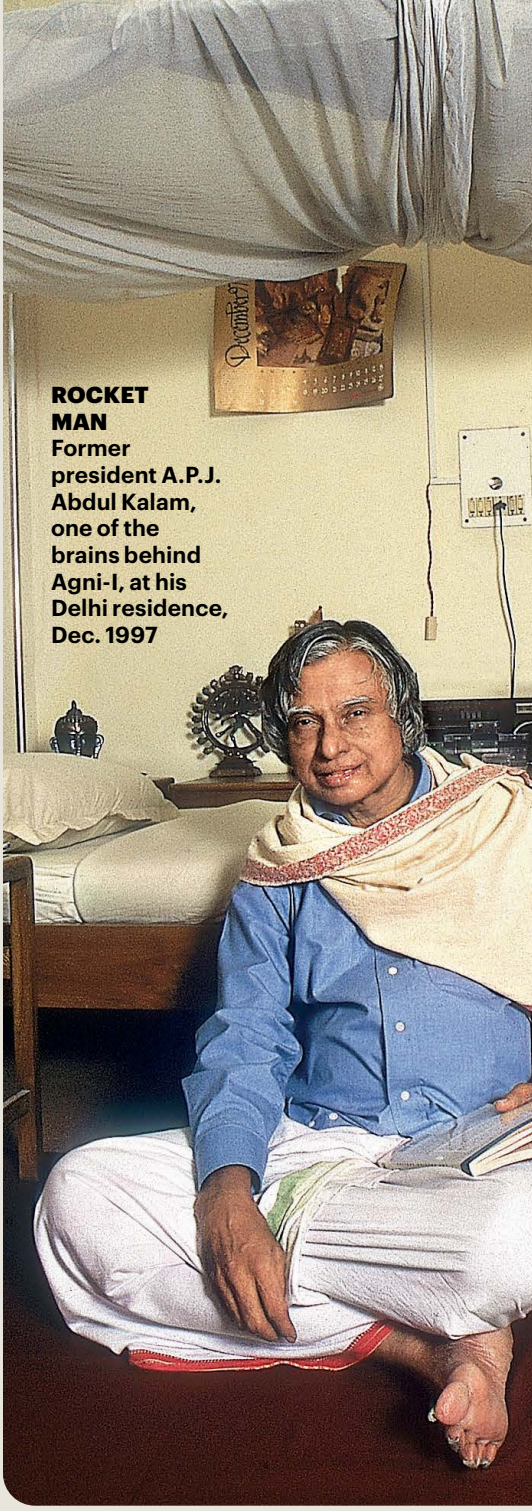
BY PRADIP R. SAGAR

The early morning calm at the Interim Test Range at Chandipur, Odisha, was torn apart as a 15-metre-long missile was hurled upward by a mobile launcher, then drilled its way through the pale blue sky amidst a bluster of fire and smoke. It was May 22, 1989, the start of the journey of India's first intermediate-range ballistic missile (IRBM), Agni-I. Initiated in 1983 and developed under the Integrated Guided Missile Development Programme (IGMDP) under A.P.J. Abdul Kalam, Agni-I was the culmination of years of technological innovation and a pivotal moment in the evolution of India's strategic defence. It conferred prestige too—India was now part of a select club of nations capable of developing IRBMs.

Agni-I was originally designed as a two-stage missile and later adapted as a single-stage ballistic missile, combining technologies from the Prithvi short-range ballistic missile and advanced solid-

DID YOU KNOW?

Agni-I, deployed operationally and with a conventional warhead, could destroy a major military installation anywhere in South Asia, including in Afghanistan. Major targets in southern and central China are within range too



ROCKET MAN Former president A.P.J. Abdul Kalam, one of the brains behind Agni-I, at his Delhi residence, Dec. 1997

QUIVERFUL OF ARROWS

» **Since 1989, India's medium- and long-range missile programme has matured, marked by increased self-reliance and integration with other defence systems**

» **India has a wide spectrum of ballistic and cruise missiles, including the BrahMos, Prithvi and long-range Agni variants**